

like me took advantage of that, printing out ten to twenty coupons on body wash, and then gathering manufacturer coupons for the same brand. Combined, the two coupons netted bottles of body wash for less than a dime. That year I gave baskets of body wash to all my siblings, completing the gift with a one-dollar body puff. Voila! Cheap gift! It wasn't long before Target began limiting the number of their coupons that could be used each transaction, ruining a bit of the fun for extreme couponers. Cashing in on two cheap body washes isn't nearly as exciting as getting ten bottles for a dollar.

The web, by its very nature of reaching millions of people and defying regulation, also made counterfeiting coupons easier than ever. The very first Internet coupons were PDF files that could easily be copied or manipulated with a different value amount or expiration date. Just as consumer product makers embraced the ease of the Internet for coupon distribution, the first wave of counterfeit Internet-printed coupons hit the stores in 2002. By 2003 stores across the country were refusing to accept any coupons printed from the Internet.

Purveyors of printable coupons such as SmartSource, CoolSavings, and Coupons.com got savvy fairly quickly, coding the coupons to track them and developing a program that only allowed two printings per computer of each coupon. With some of those safeguards in place, stores that had initially banned Internet coupons started accepting them again.

According to the Carolina Manufacturer Services Incorporated, by 2001, consumers were downloading 114 million coupons, and by the first half of 2010, NCH Marketing Services reported that the Internet was the fastest